

The Northgate Observer

COMMENT

EDUCATION

Switch Them Off: Smartphones Have No Place in Our Schools

Every school should ban phones completely, argues our columnist. The only thing stopping them is a lack of courage.

By **Martin Hale** · Columnist

- 1 Walk into any secondary school today and you will see the same depressing scene: rows of teenagers hunched over glowing screens, thumbs twitching, eyes glazed. Our children are not learning; they are scrolling. It is time for every school in the country to ban smartphones completely. Not in lessons, not at lunch, not at all.
- 2 The evidence is overwhelming. A survey by the Campaign for Screen-Free Childhoods found that 87% of teachers believe phones damage concentration. When one school in my own town introduced a ban last year, its head teacher told me that exam results “improved almost overnight”. And everyone knows that social media is designed to be addictive. The technology companies themselves have practically admitted it.
- 3 Some will argue that phones are useful for research, or that parents need to reach their children in an emergency. These are excuses, not arguments. Schools managed perfectly well for centuries without pocket computers, and any genuine emergency can be handled through the school office, exactly as it was in my day.
- 4 Others claim that teenagers must learn to manage technology responsibly rather than having it taken away. But we do not teach road safety by letting children play on the motorway. Young people simply lack the self-control to resist apps engineered by thousands of the world’s cleverest programmers. Expecting them to do so is not trust; it is negligence.
- 5 The cost of doing nothing is frightening. A whole generation is growing up anxious, lonely and unable to hold a conversation, let alone finish a novel. Every parent I speak to says the same thing: they feel they are losing their children to a screen. How many more young lives must be damaged before we act?
- 6 A ban is simple, cheap and immediately effective. Head teachers should stop hiding behind consultations and working groups and show some backbone. Lock the phones away at the school gate, and give our children back their childhoods.

Martin Hale is a former sales director and a weekly columnist for *The Northgate Observer*. He has two grandchildren.

Meridian Business Review

VIEWPOINT

THE FUTURE OF WORK

Remote Work Has Quietly Won. Employers Should Stop Fighting It.

Companies demanding a full return to the office are ignoring the evidence and risk losing their best people.

By **Sofia Brandt** · Guest contributor

- 1 Several years after offices around the world reopened, many executives are still waiting for things to “return to normal”. They may be waiting a long time. The debate over remote work is, for all practical purposes, over, and employees have won it.
- 2 Consider the numbers. According to a survey of 1,200 office workers by the Flexible Futures Institute, 71% said they would look for a new job if they were forced back to the office full time. Productivity, meanwhile, has held up remarkably well: several studies suggest that people working from home are at least as productive as their office-based colleagues. Add the savings on commuting, the reduced pressure on city transport and the lower carbon emissions, and the case becomes difficult to argue with.
- 3 It would be naive to pretend that remote work has no drawbacks. Some managers report that spontaneous collaboration is harder on video calls, and a minority of employees say they feel isolated. These concerns are understandable. However, they are largely problems of management rather than location, and well-run teams have found that regular virtual check-ins and the occasional in-person away day go a long way towards solving them.
- 4 What is harder to justify is the growing number of companies issuing back-to-the-office mandates. Too often, these appear to be driven less by evidence than by a desire for control, and in some cases by the need to justify expensive leases on half-empty buildings. Employees can tell the difference, and the most talented of them are voting with their feet.
- 5 The organisations that thrive in the next decade will be those that accept this reality rather than resist it. That means investing in digital tools, training managers to judge people by results rather than visibility, and trusting staff to decide where they do their best work. The alternative is to watch competitors hire the people you could not keep.
- 6 The office is not dead; it is simply no longer the default. The sooner employers make peace with that, the better.

Sofia Brandt is the founder of Brandt Remote, a consultancy that helps companies move to remote and hybrid working.

CRITIQUING AN OPINION ARTICLE



Read the opinion article provided by your teacher, then answer the questions below. Support your answers with clear reasons and examples from the article.

1 MAIN ARGUMENT

In one sentence, summarize the writer's main argument:

2 EVIDENCE USED

List 2-3 pieces of evidence the writer gives:

1.

2.

3.

3 IDENTIFYING BIAS

Check any indicators of bias you notice:

- ☐ Loaded language
- ☐ One-sided sources
- ☐ Emotional appeals
- ☐ Sweeping generalizations
- ☐ Omitted perspectives
- ☐

Example from the article:

4 YOUR RESPONSE

Do you agree or disagree with the writer? Explain your reasoning and refer to the article.

5 REFLECTION



How credible is the writer's evidence? Why?



Which persuasion techniques are most effective in the article?



What would make the argument more balanced or convincing?
